

New vernacular

In the 19th century, vernacular architecture came to describe functional buildings made with local materials and labour. A century or so on, new vernacular has come to refer to architecture that reinterprets traditional forms, materials and construction techniques to suit local tastes and cultures – in part to express individuality in design, but also to avoid what has been derogatorily nicknamed ‘global blandness’.

The London Olympic Velodrome (opposite, 2012) by Hopkins Architects, is clad in red cedar and designed to reflect the flowing movement of cycling. Oslo’s Onda Restaurant (2010–11), designed by Norwegian firm Alliance Arkitekter, is an undulating structure of durable, environmentally friendly local pine, combined with a simple, sheer glass façade and galvanized steel gratings, while Iceland’s PK Arkitektar has designed modern rural cottages with traditional timber walls and turf-covered roofs. In China, Wang Shu (b.1963) and Lu Wenyu (b.1966) mixed recycled materials and regional influences in their award-winning Ningbo Museum (2008).

